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Chuck Israels

Bassist and composer Chuck Israels was born in New York City on August 10, 1936. He has performed and recorded with a diverse roster of jazz luminaries including John Coltrane, Herbie Hancock, and Bill Evans. Chuck directed the National Jazz Ensemble from 1973 to 1981 and he currently directs a jazz nonet in Portland, Oregon.

Chuck was interviewed via Zoom on June 11, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Chuck Israels with me today. Welcome, sir.

CI: Thank you. Glad to be here. Glad somebody's interested in something for a minute.

MR: I want to congratulate you on your career thus far and the fact that you're continuing it in Portland. I usually try to think of some way to do an introduction and I happen to be reading my [air quotes] new *Encyclopedia of Jazz* circa 1960. And did you know that you're in it?

CI: I believe I did. I don't think I've looked at it for a long time. I think at some point I was concerned that people were paying attention to me and now I know they're not.

MR: Well I am. So it's interesting because I'll just read a little bit of it. This is probably an update from his 1955 Leonard Feather original edition. And it says: "Chuck Israels, bass, born in New York City 1936, attended junior high in Cleveland, then to New York City where he went to the High School of Performing Arts, attended MIT, president of the Symphony Orchestra, self-taught on bass from 1955, studied music at Brandeis." It mentions Herb Pomeroy and of course it mentions your gig with Billie Holiday and Dakota Staton.

CI: Yeah, Dakota Staton is wrong.

MR: Okay.

CI: I don't know why that came in there but it seems to be stamped on my biography. I never met her, I don't know why that's in there.

MR: Yes.

CI: Stuff happens.

MR: It mentions the LP with Cecil Taylor and I sort of love reading this stuff because you had your whole career ahead of you.

CI: Yes.

MR: Did you have a philosophy, a form of philosophy about bass playing in your early career?

CI: It's an interesting question, I'm not sure that I had anything so that I could call myself formed enough to have a philosophy. I think I was very much wanting to be a member of the club that included people, that was populated by people many of whom didn't look like me, and who had a cultural milieu, a musical milieu that attracted me so deeply, that felt so much like me that I wanted to belong in it. So whatever I was thinking about playing was focused on how I could play, to be part of that group of people and be part of that music. So I don't think it was particularly focused on how am I, what kind of personal individual contribution I could make so much as how can I be, how can I join this and be accepted, and be part of it.

MR: Was part of it trying to find your way in the culture of it? Not just the playing but the nightlife and the language and the camaraderie.

CI: Absolutely. And I had to do that in my own personal way. White, middle class Jewish kid from an educated family, hanging out with other quite smart people but whose smarts were oriented in slightly different ways from mine and some of whom were drinking and smoking pot and I wasn't ready for any of that. So I had to figure out how to be in it and a part of it without, well I had to find a way to fit in. And interestingly it was a pretty wide open society of people that would accept me being there, even though I wasn't doing everything that some of the other people were doing. I wasn't alone of course, there were other people like me. I grew up playing with Steve Kuhn and Arnie Wise, another couple of Jewish kids that were attracted to the music.

MR: I'm not going to spend a lot of time on this but you, in a fairly recent interview which I thought was done very well from a fellow out there, you spoke about being in a hotel room with Bill Evans and watching him basically shoot up and I'm wondering why the drinking and the drugs has been associated with jazz. I'm sure it's overblown but you are saying it was part of the scene. Do you know why?

CI: No. Maybe just staying up late at night, I'm not sure. I'm going to close the door so I don't hear the practicing the flute too much. Okay. I don't really know the answer to that. That's someone else's area of expertise. And interestingly it has totally evaporated from — you know as I went through my jazz career the presence of drugs and drinking diminished, diminished, diminished, diminished to the point where everybody was healthy people and vegetarians and exercisers, a lot smarter.

MR: Yes. And I'm very happy to hear that. Do you think of yourself — like many jazz musicians, you've worn many hats. Perhaps you were a player first, then you became a composer, in fact you can correct me if this is not right but on that first recording you did with John Coltrane it looks like you had a tune on the record.

CI: Yes and boy that was just something — something that just happened. I had this little

Brandeis. And I thought okay I'm going to take these two little figures and juxtapose them — and they're sort of harmonically ambiguous enough that they can go against each other, against changing harmony, they're kind of non-committal melodically in that sense and I put them one here and one here and one here and one here, I just tried to figure out a way that these two things would fit together and make a little tune. And it was just sitting on my music stand and I don't remember whether it was John Coltrane or Kenny Dorham or one of the wind players that went, "Oh let's play this." That's how that happened.

MR: Oh that is wonderful.

CI: Yeah, it was wonderful.

MR: When you were working on it did you even conceive it as a jazz tune?

CI: Yes, oh yes, yes.

MR: Okay. And then you did a quick arrangement on the spot?

CI: Yeah I mean it was set to a blues so it was nothing to do but play the tune, I'd play blues. So it was easy enough to do. I thought it was awfully friendly of those guys to — you know, older than me, to consider the possibility that this might be something worth doing.

MR: When we read in your bios that you performed early on with Billie Holiday and John Coltrane and Cecil Taylor, I think it's hard for us to go back to that time and imagine what were those musicians, what was their reputation at the time. Were your knees shaking because, oh I'm playing with John Coltrane?

CI: Not so much John because at that point John was one of the respected tenor players of the day, not the icon that he later became. I certainly liked his playing in some ways I want to say that I liked his earlier playing better than some of his later music for a number of reasons that I have explored a lot in the book that I'm writing, how the music changed and what different things influenced it. Billie Holiday I certainly knew how revered she was and that was — was that a year earlier? I can't remember if that was in the same year or what — I get my chronological sequences a little out of joint from time to time — I was pretty young, I was 22 when I played with Billie. And when people ask me about it I tell the same story and that is that I don't remember that much about what she sang or how she was because I was so necessarily preoccupied with doing the job well.

MR: I related to that immediately because I was lucky enough to play behind Aretha Franklin once in the saxophone section, and I found that within the first five minutes that I had to stop paying attention to her because I wasn't covering my part.

CI: Exactly.

MR: It was a bit of a drag, like I have to ignore Aretha Franklin.

CI: Sure, yeah. Well it was like that with Billie too. And I must have done well enough because she was certainly complimentary afterwards and comfortable with me and with Jimmy Zitano, the drummer that I had recommended that they bring from Boston to play with her, fine, fine drummer. We just spent a few minutes in the afternoon with Mal Waldron, the pianist, and went over a few things, and then bam we were onstage for the concert and, just as you described, if you don't have a lot of room in your mind to pay attention to your surroundings when you're new to the part that you're playing.

MR: I want to read something that came from your blog, and it has to do with that period of time I believe — I won't read the whole thing but I found it quite interesting. "The musicians who grew up playing jazz in the U.S. in the 1940s and 50s had every reason to believe that they were pursuing their artistic activities in an atmosphere of common understanding with the members of the audience. Most musicians felt they were following or perhaps creating together a common aesthetic." Why back then do you think the audience and the musicians were closer than I assume you think they are today?

CI: It's an essential question. And the answer to it is that I grew up in a most unusual period of time, one that I perceived from the inside as having been completely normal and it was in fact historically abnormal and that was a period in which, starting roughly in the late nineteenth century and going through to a little past the middle of the twentieth century, a period when popular music was created by and consumed by educated people. And that's a most unusual historical phenomenon.

MR: Well why has the increase — phenomenal increase in jazz education since the early 70s, can I extrapolate and say that you don't think it has improved the audience for the music?

CI: In small ways yes but mostly not. And it's much bigger than the jazz education industry, and I use that word slightly pejoratively but not entirely. It just is a way to talk about it. The only other period that I know of in which popular art seemed also to be at this kind of high level is the period of Elizabethan theater. You know I'm talking about the period starting with Scott Joplin and Jelly Roll Morton and John Philip Sousa, that's the late nineteenth century, and carrying through Louis Armstrong and the swing era and the bebop era, and all during that time jazz and popular music were connected. They were using the same material. There was a continuity of musical material and thought. It reached back, as a matter of fact it reached back hundreds of years back to Bach and beyond. And there was this musical continuity. You could see this developing over this, and this being added to this, and nothing more is really discarded, nothing was thrown away. In the mid-1960s when the baby boom generation reached adolescence that rich cultural era was decimated by this enormous population of teenagers who had money, not on purpose, it just was a socio-cultural event. So all these undeveloped people, and as we

undeveloped people with money in their pockets became the target of the market machinery. And their music, their adolescent music and adolescent musical ideas, undeveloped musical ideas, took over and marginalized everything else. And that is, and now we're in that system and have been there since roughly the mid-60s. It's hard to put a date on it but, or the late 60s. And now I think we're in a much more normal situation in which good cultural things are subsidized by institutions of educated and basically wealthy people. And that in general the popular music of the masses, the masses of all of these people whom I have every reason to love except about that, their music is now all disposable stuff and it won't be — it has no durability at all — you will never remember a Beyoncé song or a Prince song. Those are not going to become cultural icons of America in spite of — no matter how many articles are written about them in *The Atlantic* or *The New Yorker*, they'll be gone.

MR: I don't disagree with you but we probably could find people who do.

CI: Oh we can find plenty of people who do. Absolutely. But they're wrong.

MR: Can I conclude then that listening to jazz, especially not jazz vocalists but instrumental jazz, requires something more from the listener than Beyoncé or —

CI: Oh absolutely.

MR: And what is that, that it requires?

CI: It requires a history of understanding of language — of the musical language and what the musical language means in its abstract way.

MR: Okay, "means in its abstract way" can you extrapolate on that a little bit?

CI: Well I don't know what meaning there is in music and how to put into words what music means. I do understand that music makes me understand my humanity, my human existence, the things I feel and things I think about as this kind of human animal. And when I hear the music of another human animal, like me, I hear into the sensibility and experience of that person and I either feel connected and things in common with that or not. What that meaning is in words I can't — it's — if I could tell you what it meant in words I wouldn't have to sing. You know? Not that I can sing, but I wouldn't need to play bass or play with Bill Evans or Stan Getz. I wouldn't need that if poetry did it to me. Some people poetry does that for them. There is some kind of balance of qualities of this soundscape that we make in music that is a kind of abstract poetry for me. And when I hear this abstract musical poetry of another person, or I play with another person and we create that stuff together, I have generally connected and associated with that person's sensibility and life in a way that kind of holds away loneliness of death. It's kind of a big thing to say about it but I don't know why else we do it.

MR: You wrote, "play, sing as if you could not speak."

MR: And I believe that's what you're talking about and I really like what you just said because I struggle with this question of what does music mean, unless it's descriptive or programmatic and it's trying to describe something specifically, what does music mean? And I think it means enough if you listen to a Mozart passage and it touches you somehow, like he knew how to use the elements of music and combine them in a way that made me respond. Just like earlier this morning I was listening to your Concerto Peligroso and I was going to get to this a little later but we could go there now because I was really struck by the way that you avoided the common — okay the time's in the bass and the drums and I'm going to lay everything over that and the bass and drums are going to keep going all the time. Instead you had piano interludes, you had complex unison passages, you had ensemble work where it sounded to me like the bass was laying out and then you brought everybody together. And the texture changed frequently and kept my attention. Was that your intention?

CI: Sure.

MR: Long question, short answer.

CI: Of course. Yeah. Well I thought the bass and drums playing time feels so good but it feels better if it comes as the lagniappe at the end you know? And when I listen to that I think maybe I held it back a little too long, I'm not sure in terms of the proportions and balance and that. But boy when it comes in you think oh yeah. And that was the effect I was looking for. And you can't get that effect if you start with that. You have to build some tension and how much of this was an intellectual idea and how much of it was just — I'm not sure what my thought process is all the time, you know, but yes, certainly that was a conscious effort on my part.

MR: Okay. Those ideas, when you conceive of a composition, perhaps it's at the piano or perhaps it's taking a walk, anything in between those two, but the arrangement of it, the arrangement of the initial idea, do you think that's where those textures and so forth come from?

CI: Yes.

MR: Or arrive?

CI: Yes. They're interesting to me. I'm particularly interested in what an ensemble of instruments does together as a group. I'm certainly affected by soloists and what they can do, but I tend to write things that are focused on group interaction. Things that soloists can do often are best left to them, I mean not entirely, there are plenty of people who write wonderful solo music and I'm not saying that I never write that, but I'm more interested in, oh I can write this for this person to do or this instrument or generally I think of them as having certain kind of personalities in an abstract way. But okay, this

personality does this, and this personality responds in this way, and then the group, it's the interaction is what's interesting to me. Most interesting.

MR: Have you ever had a circumstance where a soloist was playing in a fashion that you didn't feel was contributing to the overall feeling of the piece?

CI: Occasionally.

MR: And what do you do about that?

CI: You shut up and live with it usually. It depends on the circumstance. There are circumstances in which you can stop and fix it. Most people don't do that intentionally but it has happened. It happened at a concert with the National Jazz Ensemble I think in Buffalo, I think it was a concert and Gunther Schuller was there and after the concert I talked to him about it and we both had the same response, and it was a couple of alto saxophone players got into a saxophone battle that might have been — the idea of a kind of back and forth exchange between soloists is not a bad thing — but they lost sight of the — they lost connection with the piece and started playing a bunch of stuff that they'd practiced that sort of fit harmonically but it didn't. To me I went oh God I wish they'd shut up and stop so we can finish the piece. And I remember someone telling me a real apocryphal or maybe real Ellington quote in which Jimmy Hamilton went to Ellington and said, "Hey it says clarinet solo here but it has no chord changes and stuff." And Ellington's response was, "Yeah that's because I want you to play my piece, not that stuff that you practice." So, and there's a balance of that too. Because when I leave open solo space I certainly want a contribution from the personality of the musician who is in that position. They can make enormous contributions that I don't even think of. They can bring stuff to the music that enlivens it and gives it an immediacy that my written part doesn't necessarily contain. It contains the opportunity for that because when the Guarneri Quartet sits down and plays a Beethoven quartet they do it in such a way that you believe that they're making it up. And if they don't they're not giving a good performance.

MR: I'm reminded of a quote, Dave Rivello, who is at Eastman School of Music, attributed to Bob Brookmeyer. And he said, "When you write a big band arrangement try to put off as long as you can the solo."

CI: Oh well, it depends. I mean I guess, maybe.

MR: It's a challenge you know, because we say okay we have an intro, then we do the head, whatever it is, and we'll do the bridge. And if you're A-A-B-A, and then you get to that spot, now I have a shout chorus in mind, but I can't do it yet.

CI: Yeah maybe, yeah. I also, I understand his position about that. I find Bobby Brookmeyer a kind of a difficult person because he's full of dichotomies. He has done extraordinarily

MR: Okay.

CI: I don't know what the development of his aesthetics, what he went through, but nevertheless I think he's been a thoughtful person about these things and there are some — something in what he's saying there is don't take the easy way out and just give it to the soloist, now, develop your piece further. And I think that's, as a composer, that's a valid perception, a valid goal.

MR: When you listen to your rhythm section, which you're usually a part of, can you tell when things are not swinging?

CI: Sure.

MR: And what is that about?

CI: Usually about a misalignment or a misalignment of accents or an imbalance of one kind or another. I often find that — we talked about jazz education earlier and there are a lot of people in the field of jazz education who are in a position, who are forced into a position of teaching about — teaching things about which they are insufficiently informed. And it's not entirely their fault. I don't let them completely off the hook but someone who says to the drummer, "Play strong on two and four" doesn't understand that the reason we accent two and four is simply to counterbalance the fact that all the harmonic information and a certain emphasis is happening on the first and third beats of most four-four pieces. And you don't want to overbalance — you don't want to do a counterbalance that tips the feeling of the music too far in the opposite direction. It is just as counterproductive and flat-footed to have overly strong two and four as it is to have an Octoberfest Oom-pah band or a polka band. Not that there's anything wrong with that music when it's well played, but they don't understand that and they don't have the perspective of having played with drummers and rhythm sections that have a fluidity of accent and rhythmic texture that keeps the sense of the music moving forward and has a balance of that that is agile and that senses gravity and allows you to feel perhaps graceful and agile and light-footed against the pull of gravity. All of this is just an abstract thought about, again, words about something that comes into your ears and just tickles something in your brain but it makes you understand something about the human condition — 170 pounds of me going out for a walk and going up the hill and down the hill or running — I don't run very much anymore, hardly any, or doing my silly little dance and how that feels, how my body feels against the pull of the earth.

MR: You are a poet also. I enjoyed that description. And one more quote I read from you. I think you were addressing music that bothered you. And you said, "Music which assaults the mind and restricts it with a numbing drone commands the brain not to think and holds thought hostage while it rapes the ear."

CI: Oh boy. I said — that was pretty good. That's what — I used to think that every — you remember in the 70s when George Winston's music was ubiquitous?

MR: Yes, the new age craze.

CI: I'd go into a restaurant and they'd have this Chinese water torture drip of sound of George Winston playing arpeggio triads one after the other after the other after the other. It would drive me right up the wall.

MR: Isn't it interesting to be sitting in a restaurant like that and thinking am I the only one in here who is driven to distraction by this music?

CI: Yeah. I also have had the experience of being at a party where I was specifically invited, graciously, as a new faculty member by another faculty member wanting to introduce me to his friends and make me feel welcome. And I'm at this party at this nice guy's house and he's playing a Monk record. And we're standing around having a conversation and I go up to Milt and say, " Gee Milt, please turn that off. I can't talk to people, I have to listen to that. It's not background to me."

MR: Interesting. And there was a time when you didn't like Thelonious Monk, isn't that true?

CI: That's right. That's right. Absolutely. I was terribly — I rejected that music out of hand and incorrectly and stupidly or ignorantly and that is — I lost a lot of time appreciating that and being around him when I could have been paying attention and taking a lot more in and getting a lot more value out of being in the band playing opposite his band. I played with Bobby Timmon's trio opposite Monk's quartet at the Five Spot in New York for weeks and weeks.

MR: Did you listen to his music in that particular situation with the idea that what would I do if I was his bass player?

CI: No. I didn't get that far. I was — some people have, when I've talked to them about this have excused me, probably realistically, by saying, "Of course you were focused on a particular thing. You were trying to understand and become conversant in the language of Bill Evans, Tommy Flanagan, Hank Jones, Sonny Clark were the piano players for example. And the piano playing language of Monk was so — at least superficially — diametrically opposed to that, that you couldn't take it in. You couldn't see — that was banging. You didn't want banging, you wanted — well okay, it is banging — he does bang the piano. The fact is he banged the piano in the most incredibly artistic and effective and creative and personal way that I now appreciate with almost worshipful understanding. I didn't at the time, but okay. Fortunately it happened before I died.

MR: All right. I wanted to ask you about, just a little bit about your time with Bill Evans. And I saw you say that when you got that gig, which of course was under unfortunate circumstances but nonetheless you felt you were going to get it. This was written about

standard for new generations of jazz bass players who varied their accompaniment by mixing traditional timekeeping with far-ranging countermelodies in free rhythm." Now I don't know if at that time people would have written that or if it's in retrospect, but you didn't feel any pressure to like try to recreate what he was doing?

CI: No. There was, as often happens in the world it's rarely one person who comes up with whatever it is that the new thing is. It does happen occasionally. I just heard an interesting podcast about a Hungarian woman scientist who was the instigator of the MRNA technology that — the biological technology that created the vaccines that we are using against Covid. And it seems to have been pretty much this one person's idea, but that's not normal. It's usually a bunch of people scattered about or working together or different people at different places at the same time. Scotty wasn't alone. He was a virtuoso. He was an extraordinarily hard working and demonically driven and terrifically gifted and very attractive person musically and physically. I mean he was a charismatic guy. But he wasn't the only one playing that way. He developed it I think better and more quickly and in a more advanced way than most of the rest of us, but in his kind of folk music-like way, Charlie Haden was doing it and there was a guy named Albert Stinson who died young who was also doing it and Steve Swallow was kind of thinking like that and I was playing music like that, not because we thought we were doing anything new. It was just the way we heard the music. I heard things besides quarter notes. I listened to Oscar Pettiford and John Neves and I thought hmmm, okay I want to do that. And in my desire to do that out came these other things that weren't exactly that. Because I wasn't' able to — if I'd been able to play as well as Oscar Pettiford, if I'd been able to imitate that I probably would have done it but in the shortfall came out some personality of, some different personality.

MR: Great point. At that time, much of this material that happened at the time — that's not the right word, I'm struggling here. But the idea of, who is the timekeeper?

CI: Everybody.

MR: Everybody. And has it changed since the 50s and 60s to now, to current trios and quartets that are currently creating music now. Do you believe it has changed?

CI: In principle I don't think so. In practice it depends on who's playing. The best principle is every tub sits on its own bottom. You know that? You know that? Every tub? That's what that expression means. Everybody is responsible for his or her own timekeeping properties. You don't want to be leaning heavily — every once in a while you get pushed off your foundation for a moment. And you've got to refer to somebody else for a split second. But it should only do that.

MR: I'm trying to recall if during the time you were with Bill Evans if there was a change in

CI: Yes. Three.

MR: How did — wow — how did that — did it affect the way you approached the music?

CI: I don't think so. The first drummer was Paul Motian, who did a good job. I wasn't completely enamored of his playing but I liked it. You know I didn't find it very — I didn't find it very beautiful, just the way he hit the drums. His sound. He was a kind of a vertical drummer. But it was okay and I was glad to be in the band and I don't think I was thinking critically about it, I just don't remember being — I don't remember thinking very much about it at all. It certainly didn't stop us from playing. The music was happening and it was fun. Then Paul left, I think partly because he found my playing a little more conventional — I think. I don't really know. I would have to have asked and I didn't. But I know he said at one point that he didn't like my playing that much. And then I brought Larry Bunker into the band. And Larry Bunker is one of a number of drummers that I've worked with that were absolutely superb musicians. Just superb. And not only intuitive but also educated. It was in many ways a better musician than I. [doorbell] who's at the door? Margot will have to get it. And that was a joy for me. I loved playing with Larry. It was, on every level it was perfect in terms of dynamics and sound quality and texture and volume and interaction and swing and all the things you would want. I can't say enough about it, good. It was really great. Then Larry left and, for personal reasons, to get back to California, his father-in-law had died and he had to get back to his wife. And we were looking for somebody and Bill auditioned a drummer I thought was, named Joe Chambers, and I thought this guy's going to be good. But Bill thought he was not yet developed enough. I didn't understand exactly what he meant by that. But I said why don't you try the guy I grew up playing with, Arnie Wise. And Arnie's approach to playing was — the sound quality was very much like Larry's. A very pretty drum sound. You could sit next to either of them, right next to the drumset, and have the band on the other side and you could hear through the drumset you could hear all the music on the other side. Arnie had that quality and so did Larry. So that's — and Arnie made less of a — he was more like glue gluing the bass and piano parts together. He wasn't much of an instigator of things.

MR: I see.

CI: But he would take the duet and meld that beautifully.

MR: You are a poet. So —

CI: I'm working on a book so I'm verbally oriented at the moment. And yet it never really, it doesn't substitute for hearing the music.

MR: That's true. It's true absolutely. Music is something that is very hard to pin down but people try. In fact I found this rather odd quote, Humphrey Lyttelton wrote it in 1965. He

CI: Oh, we're on it. There's all those —

MR: Right. And he said, "Chuck Israels is a superb technician who handles the double bass as easily as if it were a guitar. He's one of the reasons why musicians have come away reeling from performances by the Bill Evans Trio in a mood poised between elation and utter despair."

CI: Well he gives me too much credit for virtuosity. Well too much — it's how he saw it. It was his perception of it. And maybe the perception of some other people. From my perspective, knowing my limitations in terms of virtuosity and technical prowess I think I used my abilities efficiently and perhaps — and I was a lot faster than I am now too, but that's just — that's true. I was fast enough for the music. And faster than, but mostly it was melodic, a melodic perspective about what you could do on the bass. I tried to play tunes when I wasn't the only one doing that you know Oscar Pettiford did the same thing and Red Mitchell was the virtuoso who made all of us look silly. He was really superb. He was like Lester Young or Charlie Parker on the bass it was just gorgeous, incredible invention and freedom.

MR: I want to go back to your composing and arranging for a bit. And can you describe where inspiration comes from? How does something new get started?

CI: Other people's music.

MR: Could you give me an example?

CI: Well I wrote a piece called "Skipping Tune." It's my version of Bill Evans' piece called "Walking Up." It is built of the same mat — no, he made a piece out of these kinds of materials, exclusively these kinds of materials. Major 7 chords, minor 7 chords and no dominants. But he did it in such a way that the piece feels as if it has progress and as if the chords have harmonic intention as if they are moving forward. They're not static. It's not just this chord for a while and now arbitrarily shift to this one. It has real —

MR: [I think we've lost each other]

CI: I lost you for a minute. I'm still, I don't hear you.

MR: Are you hearing me now?

CI: Yeah.

MR: Yeah we got lost.

CI: Never mind.

MR: But yes, you were describing, in fact I heard that tune, your "Skipping Tune" and I loved the forward motion in it, and it was happy.

CI: Yes. It is happy. There doesn't have to be dominant chords in it. It's interesting. You write a piece that feels as if it moves forward and doesn't have any tritones hidden in it but it's not really — they don't do the same thing that a dominant chord does. Yeah, I

me do my own version of that. So my pieces are, they come from other musical ideas that I've heard. And that's just me. I don't care if you want to write a piece about if you're Charles Ives and you want to write the Housatonic at Stockbridge I know Stockbridge and the Housatonic River very well and I understand it's very nice. But I can't paint a picture of that in music. I can take a photograph and that's — my music is — I don't maintain that that's how everyone should do it, that's just how my mind works.

MR: Have you ever written something and then only to find out that someone already wrote it? What you wrote was so close to something else that you realized that you were sort of channeling something else?

CI: Not really. I don't think so.

MR: That's good 'cause it can be a drag.

CI: I've written something — and in answer to the experience I've had it's in the 1970s I wrote a piece that was somewhat influenced by "Maiden Voyage" and the straight eighth note music of the time which didn't interest me at all. But it didn't feel like me somehow. But I had this thought about writing a piece that had that in it. It was mostly that. But it has a relief of a double time four-four section. Short, but to me it's the piece's saving grace. It's the one thing that keeps it from being a piece that I don't like. I still don't like it anyway. But I brought it out. I wrote it in the 1970s and I was working with some very fine musicians here and made a recording of this in the last few weeks. And they said, "Oh we like this piece, let's play it." And you know that piece feels to me like a polyester leisure suit.

MR: Some people like them.

CI: Yes. The thing is these guys are in their 40s and 50s and of another generation and to them this is music that they relate to. They like the piece very much and they actually performed it very well and we recorded it. I have a terrible fear that it's going to be my hit.

MR: And you'll have to play it every night. Are you happy with the — this is an odd question but your music has gone places that probably you and I wish it hadn't. Would you have been happier if your career had started when Red Mitchell's did.

CI: Well it did pretty much.

MR: Okay well then my timing's off. But were there eras of music that you wish you had participated in? Earlier on?

CI: I never thought about it. I haven't thought about that. Huh. My mother used to say, "What if there were no hypothetical questions?" Think about that.

MR: Let me get back to you on that, okay?

CI: It hasn't occurred to me. I feel tremendously lucky to have had, to have been born and to have had my artistic life happen when it happened. Had it happened a little bit earlier maybe that would have been good but then I wouldn't be alive now talking to you so —

MR: Okay. So I'm happy. Okay a couple of things to wrap up with. You know usually when I get ready for an interview or most interviewers they do their homework and they might pick four or five topics that they definitely want to get to in the time they have. But those are not always the topics that the interviewees might pick. So I'm wondering if there's something that you would like to talk about that I haven't asked or that no one else has ever asked?

CI: Well not that no one else has ever asked, but something I think about all the time is the discontinuity of musical language that happened roughly in the late 60s. And it happened not only in jazz it happened in popular music, it happened in theater music. You know the difference between Gershwin and Arlen, Frank Loesser, Cole Porter, and Andrew Lloyd Weber, there's a chasm, an absolute chasm. All the rest is continuous music from pre-Bach, through Baroque classical romantic twentieth century music and the threads go back through that and all of a sudden all these threads are broken. That doesn't make any sense to me. I don't relate to that. I don't relate to "Hamilton" as music. It's discontinuous.

MR: Could it have anything to do with technology?

CI: Sure.

MR: Everything keeps getting better and better — technology in the theater, lights and sets and all that. And maybe somehow the music was conceived as we don't need it to be as deep as it used to be.

CI: I don't know. That's a good thought. That's certainly possible. Certainly that is a fact that things have skewed that way. Whether it's a result or an intention I'm not in a position to judge that. I'm more inclined to think that it's a result of the same problem that I think pop music has and that is that we reverted to cheap popular music sometime in, kind of in the middle of my lifetime, you know in my 30s and 40s. The things that had built — on which our popular music was built, going back to Stephen Foster and the music my grandmother sang to me, what I heard on the radio when I was a child. You know you heard Cole Porter, you heard Gershwin, you heard Fats Waller, you heard Duke Ellington, you heard all sorts of cheap stuff, but not entirely. And then at a certain point all of that went away, that you no longer heard Rosemary Clooney sing or Bing Crosby sing or Frank Sinatra sing. That that was gone. And for a while there was this Motown music that wasn't so bad, it had a lot of good things in it. And then pretty much that dissipated too and you have nothing but, well what to me is empty-headed, empty-

and I don't feel close to them. I don't feel that they are — I understand their anger and their displeasure, I mean but I don't feel connected.

MR: I'll close with — I've so much enjoyed this conversation and the way you describe things. I forget if I read this or if I heard it in that aforementioned interview. You said it's an instinct for humans to be somewhat prejudiced, that it's part of their human nature to question or feel somewhat threatened by people who are different.

CI: I think so.

MR: Do you think it's getting worse?

CI: I don't know. It certainly seems to be threatening socio-politically at the moment. But at the same time that there are a lot of people who I think are succumbing to their prejudices I think we all have them. That was kind of my point is I think we all have them. And the question is not whether or not you have them but whether or not you succumb to them. As many people as there are that are succumbing to them, there's also kind of a big group of people who say no, we don't do that. It's rather polarized and we are experiencing a moment of the exposure of the polarization. It's too big a subject to feel as if I have any control over or any real historical perspective on it, but it is a little scary. And certainly when you see the machinery of political power and political power hunger, when you see that machinery grinding and moving in ways and grinding towards things that historically remind you of Nazism and authoritarianism and all of those things and you see a lot more of that in a general way, it's a little frightening. No question. I grew up as a teenager in the McCarthy era so a lot of my friends were, and friends of my family — not my friends but my parents' friends were terribly threatened by that. Paul Robeson, Lester Cole who was one of the Hollywood Ten, Dalton Trumbo, people like that, Zero Mostel. Yet even though there was Joe McCarthy and the House Un-American Activities Committee it wasn't the whole government. We've lived through four years of the whole government being governed by corrupt hunger for power. And I have lived through, I'm 84, in the 80 other years, as negative as some things have been it was never like that.

MR: Is that something, that feeling, is that something you would write music about?

CI: No.

MR: Okay. I think I knew the answer to that from what you have said earlier. So really thank you for your time. I have one last quick question, when do titles arrive for you when you composes?

CI: Sometimes before the piece, sometimes there's a list of them and I just stick one on. Because they mostly, it's pretty hard to describe. It could be Composition #1, Composition #3, Composition #47 so the answer is they come kind of arbitrarily. I've got to give it a name.

MR: Right. It needs a name. Who was the sax player who would have diagrams and — Anthony Braxton. Sometimes he would have like little drawings and stuff, that was the title.

CI: Uh huh. Well I can understand that.

MR: Okay. Well I appreciate your time today and it was a fascinating conversation. I wish you best of luck that your nonet continues and that you continue composing and so forth.

CI: Thanks, Monk. Well I appreciate it. I miss the east, I miss where you are, all of that. That's my territory. It feels strange to be out here. I've been out here half my life almost, not quite, almost, yeah, almost half my life, and it feels like — it's okay it's beautiful. The weather's better. We're in a blue state in a blue city basically. So things are — it's not terrible.

MR: Okay.

CI: But I miss New England, I miss New York, I miss upstate New York and Vermont. That's home to me. So enjoy the things I'm missing.

MR: Okay. Maybe there's a song title in there.

CI: Anyway thank you very much for your interest and attention. Is this recorded video as well or just —

MR: Yes. This is going to be on video. And we have a YouTube channel. So I'll pause our recording and then we'll say goodbye.

CI: Okay. Thank you very much.